serious problems in the jail.

The prison atmosphere, however, was not yet free from fear. The gangsters and hardened criminals, about 40 in all, were spread over all the prisons. There were deep-rooted animosities and hatred amongst them and, whenever they got an opportunity, they would fly at each other's throats. They still spread fear amongst a large number of the undertrials and could still manage to dictate terms. All the opportunities offered to the rest were offered to them too, but to no avail. They continued on their self-destructive path. They stood warned, and yet they stood unmoved.

It was this group that would put pressure on the other inmates to resist the changes being effected in the prison. The reformative attempts that were being made were adversely affecting the sway and clout they exercised. To date, they had been functioning undisturbed by their incarceration and it was conducive to their wellbeing to permit the old order to continue.

Hardly any one of these hardened criminals would have had eaten prison food. Each prisoner was permitted two *mulaqaats*, or meetings, per week. These visits had been so organized that almost every day each group would be getting home-cooked food brought by the visitors. Their visitors would come, enter false names and addresses in the *mulaqaat* register, and request permission to meet specific members of these groups. Earlier, of course, for the reasons explained, these visits would take place in the rooms of the administrative block and not in the regular visitors' room. During the new regime the old practice was stopped, but it still did not prove much of a deterrent because the identities of the visitors were still being concealed.

Members of these groups were therefore marked and it was made known that anyone visiting them would have to seek permission from the jail authorities by giving a 24-hour notice. This enabled the administration to verify the bona fides of the visitors and their addresses. In almost all the cases, it was discovered that the names and addresses were false. It was apparent that no one wanted himself or herself to be openly associated with any member of these gangs. The visits, therefore, stopped.

Naturally, these prisoners stepped up their disruptive activities and became more determined to offset the reform programme.

In November 1993, they were all transferred to a common barracks in Jail 1. Privileges extended to the other inmates were withdrawn from them, till they showed the willingness to even consider changing their attitudes.

Joseph Obi recalled the sight of these gangsters being transferred to a common ward: 'There were these forty-odd guys lined up. And the stuff they had with them. They all had their own sleeping bags and portable TVs and video players. They sure seemed to have been having a comfortable stay here. And then the IG ordered a list of all their stuff to be made against their names and everything to be kept in jail custody. Each prisoner was given his quota of prison blankets and sent off to the ward.'

Facilities of ceiling fans were withdrawn. Also, they had to face a series of 'no's': No canteen facilities; no special *mulaqaats;* no games; and no reading material. In fact, they were most effectively isolated. 'These were *privileges* that the jail extends to the prisoners,' explained the superintendent. 'We are not bound by the Prisons Manual to extend them to the prisoners. The choice was left to us. In their case, their conduct and behaviour were not deserving of these privileges.'

If they had to go to court, then the police van drove into their ward and they boarded it directly from their barracks.

They certainly were not going to take such treatment lying down. They filed petitions in court.

The court heard their case and sent an official of the court to look into their living conditions. The superintendent of the jail, K. R. Kishore, effectively defended the case by filing a convincing affidavit.